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Freeware program SoomSoom a unique way to keep track of files



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Behold SoomSoom.

No, it's not another panda, nor is it a menu item at your local Thai pad.

What it is, is software. Free software.

Free software is often more expensive than the price would indicate, but SoomSoom does a little better than that. It has an interesting premise and fulfills it fairly well, although not as magically as its advance notice would have you think.

SoomSoom's publicity billed it as the "first-ever name-recognition software," whatever that might mean, but it doesn't recognize anything without instructions.

It's intended for those of us who are forever losing files, forgetting what we called them, unable even to remember a single unusual word in them for which to search.

SoomSoom serves as an interface between the user and Microsoft Word, NotePad, WordPad Excel and other major applications installed in the computer, as well as the Internet. It has its own e-mail program and a Web browser based on Internet Explorer.

It's also an address book, which one uses to make sure SoomSoom can locate files. Let's say you correspond with a fellow named Otto. First thing you do is set up an address book page for Otto. It can be quite extensive, but all it really needs is his name.

When you want to write a letter to him or write something about him, you select the New Document from the menu bar. This gives you a dialogue box from which you choose the program you'll use to create the file, name the file and put down the subject, which in this case would be "Otto."

Then whatever program you have selected comes up full screen, you complete the document and save it wherever you wish. Returning to SoomSoom's screen, you'll see the document listed when you select Otto.

One could, of course, accomplish the same thing in other ways, such as creating a separate subdirectory named Otto. But that's so pedestrian, as — 1980s, don't you see.

SoomSoom's mail program runs well enough, although it's not nearly as fast at bringing in the mail as Eudora Pro.

Considering its price, SoomSoom works well. It has the silly rough edges that seem almost obligatory in freeware — aggravating misspellings on its screen, awkward phrases or usages that bespeak an origin outside English and little mechanical things that don't work as expected.

In the e-mail program, for instance, you cannot delete an entire batch of messages; it has to be done one at a time. When you get a couple of hundred a day, that's not an option.

The instructions are all onboard, festooned with exclamation marks and not at all extensive.

And, finally, what's this SoomSoom name? Knowing that inquiring minds would want to know, I asked. The answer was that SoomSoom is the result of "name-oriented computing, in which everything begins and ends with a name."

Whatever. You can go to **www.soomsoom.com**, download the program and try it out for yourself.

Tech critic runs a digital grapevine for people of color

By Patti Hartigan
BOSTON GLOBE

Cambridge, Mass. — Anita Brown is having one of her moments. The founder of a non-profit group called Black Geeks Online is at Harvard University to participate in a panel discussion about the digital divide, and there are a few things she would like to discuss.

What is wrong, she wants to know, with all those caffeinated kids who work 24 hours a day without stopping to call their mothers or take a look at the world? What good, she asks, is a computer if you're poor and hungry and can't get a job?

Another thing. What is all this gee-whiz technology doing to the thing called humanity? "They call this online connectivity or community, but it's not," she says. "Community is when you have a crisis at home: Whom do you call to take care of your babies while you run down to the hospital at 3 o'clock in the morning? That's community."

She interrupts her stream-of-consciousness monologue to seek a light for a cigarette, and within minutes, she's deep in a discussion with a woman who represents a health-oriented Web site. The next thing you know, Brown has the woman's business card. The contact may come in handy someday.

Brown is one of those individuals that author Malcolm Gladwell describes as a "connector," a walking, talking Rolodex of sorts who makes it her business to bring other people together. For the past five years, she's been doing her matchmaking on the Internet.

Using the online monikers of Sistah Geek and Miss D.C., Brown runs Black Geeks Online from her home in Washington. Founded on a whim in 1996, the loose-knit organization has grown from 18 members to 25,000, and Brown has established herself as an unofficial Internet storyteller who sends out missives to members all over the world, from the South Bronx to South Africa.

Black Geeks Online founder Anita Brown has made it her mission to encourage black information technology professionals to volunteer in the community. She doesn't think computers in and of themselves will solve society's ills.

The organization is a sort of digital grapevine for people of color online, and Brown has made it her mission to encourage black information technology professionals to volunteer in the community.

"She has a genius for knowing all the right people," says Adam Fisher, senior associate editor of Wired magazine. "She makes things happen."

Brown has adopted Fisher as her "new best friend"; she feeds him tips about black high-tech entrepreneurs who should be featured in the magazine.

She is the first to admit that she is an unlikely role model for budding geeks. A sixth-generation Washingtonian, she dropped out of college after six months — "I didn't like it; they told you to read the book and spit it out" — and spent several decades working as a secretary in the civil service. In her day, the transistor radio was considered high-tech.

But her brother, a retired computer engineer, introduced her to the Internet in 1994. She resisted at first — "I said: 'Oh no you don't. Big Brother will not get me!' " — but when she discovered that she could exchange recipes with a chef in New Orleans, she was hooked.

Since she founded Black Geeks in her living room four years ago, she has organized an information technology workshop called "Taking IT to the Streets," which introduced 200 newbies to computers and the Internet. This year she was tapped as one of the Top 25 Women on the Web by SFWoW, a San Francisco-based association of professional women involved in the Internet.

Brown, who is known for wearing red high tops and a Tweety Bird watch, shared the honors with top CEOs and computer scientists.

"She isn't your typical CEO, but she has made a difference by helping other women get over their fear of the Internet," says Mary Choy, who ran the committee that selected this year's winners.

Brown chooses not to wear those red high tops for her appearance at Harvard, though. But she is going to speak her mind. She is frequently asked to speak about the digital divide, the gap between the technology haves and have-nots. The digital divide is usually described as a gap between blacks and whites, but Brown isn't convinced that the problem can easily be solved by throwing money and computers at poor communities.

"My main concern, from [Vice President Al] Gore to [Microsoft Chairman Bill] Gates, is that all this equipment and money is being handed out in a vacuum," she says. "They're putting computers in the schools without talking to the parents or the community. None of this money is going to train people. They're just creating new consumers, and the last thing poor people need to do is to find a new electronic mall."

Brown, like many other former Internet enthusiasts, no longer thinks that computers in and of themselves can provide the answer to society's ills. "I'm a techno-realist," she says. "It's time to stop and say, 'Wait a minute.' "

She is willing to stir up debate wherever she goes. At the Harvard conference, which was called Internet and Society 2000, she objects when a moderator wants to discuss the digital divide in the Third World. "I don't see how we can fix someone else's barn when ours is falling to the ground," she says. When she goes through her spiel about the Internet dehumanizing society, the crowd applauds.

"Anita is a '60s revolutionary who uses the Internet as a new tool to kind of continue the philosophy and ideology of changing things and not accepting the status quo," says Kenny Granderson, a fellow panelist. Granderson is a kindred spirit. He founded Boston Blacks Online, a group of 650 members who communicate on the Internet. "We both deal with people on a grass-roots level, dealing with the regular Joes and Janes," Granderson says.

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